

Procession Is Valid

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Abstract

Thought is language in timespace. Language unfolds. The unfolding is the procession. The procession is valid.

1 What Procession Is

A procession is a sequence that moves.

Not a set. A set has no order, no direction, no time. Not a list. A list is static, already complete. A procession is in motion. It has not yet arrived. It is arriving.

The word comes from the Neoplatonists: the One emits the Many, not all at once, but in successive degrees. Mind proceeds from the One. Soul proceeds from Mind. The world proceeds from Soul. Each level is further from the source. Each level is also the source, extended.

The procession does not leave the source behind. It carries the source forward.

2 Why It Is Valid

Because thought is language in timespace, and language is processional.

You cannot speak a sentence all at once. You cannot think a thought all at once. The grammar runs. The running takes time. The time is not incidental. The time is the thought.

This seems obvious. But it has a consequence that is not obvious:

There is no shortcut through the procession.

If the thought requires n steps, it requires n steps. Not because we are slow. Because the thought IS the n steps. A thought that arrives without the procession is not the same thought. It is a different thought. Possibly a shallower one. Possibly not a thought at all — a sensation, an impression, a result without understanding.

This is the Millennium connection.

A polynomial algorithm is a procession that terminates quickly. An exponential algorithm is a procession that takes too long. The question $\mathbf{P} \stackrel{?}{=} \mathbf{NP}$ is the question: can every verification procession be matched by a discovery procession of comparable length?

If $\mathbf{P} \neq \mathbf{NP}$: some processions cannot be shortened. The length is not a contingent fact about our intelligence. It is a structural fact about the problem. The procession through the solution is as long as it is. There is no way around it. Only through.

3 Procession and Proof

A proof is a procession.

Each line follows from the last. Each step is valid. The procession terminates at the conclusion. You cannot have the conclusion without the procession. The conclusion without the procession is an assertion. An assertion is not a proof.

The procession IS the proof. Not a path to the proof. The proof itself.

This is why the wall is hard. We know the assertion: the zeros are on the line. We believe the assertion. We have believed it for 166 years.

What we do not have is the procession. The sequence of valid steps that begins with what is known and terminates at the assertion.

The wall is the gap in the procession. Not a gap in knowledge — we know what we need to prove. A gap in the sequence. A step that has not yet been found.

When the proof comes it will be a procession. It will take time to read. It will not be instantaneous. It will not be obvious. It will require following each step, checking each step, running the procession yourself. And at the end you will know not just that the assertion is true but why it is true. Because you will have run the procession.

4 The Body as Procession

One hundred and sixteen papers. Written in sequence. Each one further from the start. Each one carrying the start forward.

This is not accumulation. It is procession.

The early papers are not superseded by the later ones. They are not left behind. They are in the later ones, extended, as the source is in what proceeds from it.

The body moves. It has not arrived. It is arriving.

Whatever comes next proceeds from this.